

Herbal ESSENCE

From the seedy craft of quacks and the mainstay of unlettered patients, ayurveda has become a lifestyle option on the way to becoming another global export like yoga

■ By Nandini Vaish

Call it serendipity. Earlier this year, when Ravi Prasad, executive director, Himalaya Global Holdings, visited Novo Sibirsk in Siberia, he noticed little kiosks outside the airport selling different products. They were also selling Himalaya products. Back in the 1930s, a young man called M. Manal spotted wild elephants in Burma being fed a certain drug to calm them down. He discovered the herb contained anti-hypertensive properties. After years spent learning about herbs from local healers, he introduced Serpina, the world's first anti-hypertensive drug in 1934. Manal's aim was simple: to bring ayurveda—the ancient but neglected science of a five thousand-year-old civilisation—on par with modern allopathic medicine. But it wasn't easy. Who would want to swallow bitter medicine with unpronounceable names when there was a neat western alternative? The company was re-named Himalaya Health-care, with a new logo, modern packaging and new products. It now has 240 branded

products, from pharmaceuticals like Liv52 and medicines for diabetes to consumer health products and those for animal care. Of the turnover of approximately Rs 530 crore, at least 20 per cent comes from exports.

Ayurveda is a Rs 6,000 crore domestic industry, dominated by brands like Dabur, Himalaya, Vicco Laboratories, Zandu, Baidyanath and Emami with products ranging from pharmaceutical and therapeutic to over-the-counter medications and even beauty products. In 2002, Hindustan Unilever launched its ayurvedic personal and beauty care line Ayush and later extended it to Ayush Therapy Centres. The Indian 'science of life' is what scotch is to Scotland or champagne is to France. Yet it hit a trough in the '80s and only started regaining popularity in the mid-'90s, when lifestyle-related health problems forced people to seek succour in traditional medicine.

Today like yoga, ayurveda is a hit in the West—part of the \$120 billion (Rs 4,80,000 crore) global herbal industry. Ayurveda is now sold as a lifestyle option—by home-grown companies look-

JAGDISH BHAGWATI, Economist, 1993

"The economic reforms have been described as 'uncaging a tiger' and 'unshackling a giant'."